



Moment of jubilation: NorthEast United FC goalkeeper Gurmeet Singh celebrates after winning the Durand Cup 2024 final against Mohun Bagan Super Giant. DEBASISH BHADURI

Durand Cup.

Despite his success, there are still few players who can claim NorthEast United FC as the birthplace of their footballing careers. The club's recent Durand Cup win could serve as a catalyst for greater investment in youth development.

Recognising the need for fresh talent, Benali expanded his search to the southern regions of India, resulting in the arrival of players like Muthu Mayakkannan and more game time for Jithin M.S. These signings have since become pivotal members of the team's midfield. With his rich international experience, Benali persuaded the club's management to make key adjustments to strengthen the squad, positioning NorthEast United FC to compete with the best.

"In this moment, the team is in the building process. It is growing, and we have a lot of new players, better players with their experience. We think slowly, slowly there is a progression, and the players will start to understand the football we want for the team," Benali tried to put things in perspective. "You know, football is beautiful. It is easy to plan on the board, it is easy in training, but you need to go to the field and put what you have in mind — what you have been working on. And who better than Mohun Bagan to play against and see where we are? That's how we start to excel," Benali said about how the team was shaping up for the season.

NorthEast United narrowly missed out on a knockout berth in the previous ISL season. Still, Benali believes the upcoming season would offer the perfect opportunity to implement the extensive planning and team-building efforts.

"We need to be more stable. This is why we tried to keep as many players as possible and not make a lot of changes in the team.

"This was also the management's and the owner's idea. I am happy for it," Benali said.

The decision to maintain the core has paid off, and Benali hopes the squad can sustain this consistency in the ISL, which now presents its greatest challenge.

« Juan Pedro Benali's arrival has helped NorthEast United become competitive against giants of Indian football »»